

UTEP Pitching Staff Key To '78 Success

By MARK LEIBSON

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University of Texas at El Paso baseball coach Andy Cohen has an important ingredient which has been missing from his starting lineup in years past — a solid pitching staff.

The Miners demonstrated their strong arms through UTEP's first eight games of the season by recording two shutouts and allowing one run in two other games.

"This is the best group of pitchers I've had since Mark Bombard, Harry Milner and Jim Greggerson were here sometime in the late 60s," said Cohen after his team has rolled to a 6-2 record.

What Cohen is blessed with this season is more starting pitchers than one coach needs. "I guess you could say we have six starters and we won't be afraid to put them in at any time to win a game," said Cohen.

To illustrate UTEP's strength on its pitching staff, last year-year starter Jerry Walker, the only hurler to do well in Western Athletic Conference play, has been switched to first base besides doing some spot duty in relief.

When Walker is pitching, outfielder Dan Feagler moves to first.

Junior college transfers Jim Sacco and Nick Fiorello have already established themselves as UTEP's ace hurlers. Sacco, a righthander, has experienced some wildness so far, allowing as many walks as strikeouts.

Fiorello has averaged a strikeout an inning so far. The southpaw is one of three lefties in the starting rotation, along with Wes Zolt and Russ Bortell.

Reliever K.C. Nix from Ranger Junior College is working his way into the starting lineup.

The only handicap the Miners have had so far is at second base where Art Bravo has made several errors, one which cost UTEP a chance at defeating Brigham Young last week.

"He's usually a steady ballplayer," said Cohen. "I appointed him captain a couple of weeks ago and ever since, he's been trying too hard. You know, the captain is suppose to be the best player on the team and Art is trying to live up to that expectation. He's been trying so damn hard and nothing has been going right. Art is a good player. He'll come around."

The rest of UTEP's infield is solid with the ac-



SACCO



FIORELLO

quisition of shortstop Danny McMahon, a hard thrower with a quick release. Returning third baseman Jim Bradford has been challenged by Ron Cramer, a converted pitcher with a rifle arm to first.

Utility infielder Orlando Cordova has shown promise at third, starting these periodically. Bradford's problem has been at the plate.

"We have some people who can play more than one position which is going to help us this year," Cohen said. "There are about six outfielders we have which could start."

Bob Alsup, who has held the centerfield position for two years, was UTEP's leadoff batter until last week when Cohen moved Bravo into the leadoff position. Alsup, a good contact batter, is now third in UTEP's lineup and will bat there when the Miners host Lubbock Christian College in a noon doubleheader Monday at Tech Field.

When Walker is not at first, Fiegler moves to the infield from right. His replacement has been freshman Art Flores from Coronado who already has two home runs to lead UTEP in that department. Dan Haygood has nailed down left field.

Another area the Miners improved on greatly is behind the plate where former Irvin all-district catcher Richard Hildebrand and Austin graduate Sal Flores share duties.

"I'll be alternating Hildebrand and Flores until one proves to me that he's better than the other. Hildebrand is looked on as our number one catcher but Flores is a hard worker and has done a good job so far," praised Cohen.